

Your Autistic Friend / Neighbour (an Older Adult)

For friends, neighbours & community peers — being a good friend to an older autistic adult (roughly 60+).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means an older friend's attention has always locked into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Many were never identified and may simply be "the quiet, routine-loving one" — and **social isolation** is a real, serious risk in this group. A steady, predictable, low-pressure friendship — connection through a shared interest, no demands to "perform" warmth the typical way, and patience with a different style — can be one of the most protective things in their life.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Same routine, same topic, same seat	Predictability and a lifelong interest — anchors , not rigidity
Quiet; avoids groups, loud places, surprises	Managing a lifelong sensory/social load
Slow to answer; asks you to repeat	Processing time + possible hearing loss — not disinterest
Takes things literally; misses banter	Literal communication — say what you mean
Declines or cancels more than other friends	A finite budget, spent carefully — not about you

Try this

- **Connect through the interest** — it's where they're most themselves; let them share expertise.
- **Keep it predictable and low-pressure** — same time, same plan, no surprises.
- **Say what you mean**; allow processing time and repeats.
- **Offer low-key, quieter ways to meet** — a walk, a coffee, side-by-side over a crowd.
- **Leave the door open** — "no need to reply"; consistency beats intensity.

Avoid this

- Loud surprises, group pressure, or "come on, live a little."
- Reading quiet, a different style or a slow reply as disinterest.
- Assuming slowness or a change means decline — flag it kindly if worried.

When to get more support

Social isolation is a major risk for older autistic adults — your friendship is genuinely protective. If you notice a real change in skills, mood or engagement, share it kindly and, if appropriate, with family — distinguishing lifelong difference from decline needs careful assessment, not assumption.

If your friend is a woman

Older autistic women are especially under-identified, having masked for a lifetime; “quiet and anxious” may be unrecognised autism.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Family guide** (Part 5), **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 1) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Old-age evidence is thin; fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Klein et al. (2024, aging & autism); Milton (2012, double empathy). Full citations are in the source drafts.